

IN CONTEXT

Challenging elite monasticism

Monasteries were hugely influential institutions in Europe at the time of Hildegard's birth and had exerted their impact on economic, political, and spiritual life. Monks and nuns were often from privileged families and wielded tremendous power in the region, which led to corruption and excessive wealth. Challenges to this system emerged in the 12th century by, for example, the Cistercians—a religious order that advocated manual labor for monks and nuns—and by the religious leader Peter Waldo, who renounced his wealth, calling for voluntary poverty.



CISTERCIAN MONKS AND NUNS LABORING IN
THE FIELDS

Hildegard of Bingen—also known as St. Hildegard and the Sibyl